Important Update

2026-09-14 00:00:00

On September 14, 2026, the U.S. District Court for the District of Massachusetts issued an order pausing the effective date of the Department of Homeland Security's Duration of Status Final Rule while litigation concerning the rule continues.

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Adding a Progressive Degree Program

Jump to a Section

What Is a Progressive Degree Program?

A progressive degree program (PDP) provides a pathway for undergraduate students to accelerate the completion of a master's degree. Here's what you need to know about starting a progressive degree program at USC as an international student while maintaining visa status.

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How Are Progressive Degree Pr

Students in a progressive degree program ar attain one of the following conditions, whichever come

The first bachelor's degree is conferred,

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- The student must submit a PDP I-20 Request in Trojan International.
- An OIS55 registration hold will be placed on the student's record.
- Once the PDP I-20 is issued, the hold will be lifted.

The updated Form I-20 will reflect:

- The master's degree level and major.
- The new program start and end dates (the program end date will be revised, if needed).

Students must complete all requirements for their PDP (as well as their certificate/minor programs, if applicable) by the program end date on their PDP I-20.

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How to Transition to a Master's

Please attend OIS drop-in advising to speak

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- Once a PDP I-20 has been issued, any internship/practicum must be considered an integral part of a PDP student's master's degree program. Refer to the Curricular Practical Training (CPT) page for internship course registration details.
- A PDP I-20 cannot be canceled once issued.
- Students should not withdraw from the PDP after a PDP I-20 is issued.
- If you withdraw from a PDP after receiving your PDP I-20, your F-1 status may be jeopardized, as you cannot return to a bachelor's-level I-20 if you have already enrolled in master's-level coursework.
- Once the PDP I-20 is issued, you will not be eligible for CPT or Post-Completion OPT based on your bachelor's degree.

If you have questions about a PDP I-20 or enrollment requirements for PDP students, please contact OIS.

Optional Practical Training (OPT) Considerations

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